BVRIT MUN 2026

FOR THE DIPLOMAT IN YOU

UNHRC

Background Guide

UNITED NATIONS HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL (UNHRC)

BVRITMUN 2026

Agenda: Addressing challenges in the protection of human rights in Bangladesh, with a focus on vulnerable populations.

1. Letter from the Executive Board

Greetings, Esteemed Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Human Rights Council at BVRITMUN 2026. The agenda before you is both relevant and complex . Human rights discussions demand precision, diplomatic restraint, intellectual effort and integrity. They require delegates to differentiate between political rhetoric and binding legal obligation.

Delegates are expected to present well-researched arguments grounded in human rights, treaty law, UN mechanisms, and accurate foreign policy representation. You are encouraged to refer to relevant Universal Periodic Review documents, treaty body observations, and Special Rapporteur communications.

The situation in Bangladesh presents consequential challenges ranging over issues related to governance, displacement, civic space, gender equity and equality amongst many more. Your task is neither to indict nor to defend uncritically, but to deliberate constructively and propose implementable solutions.

We look forward to rigorous debate and diplomacy.

Warm Regards,
Executive Board
UNHRC – BVRITMUN 2026

2. Introduction to UNHRC

The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) was established in 2006 through UN General Assembly Resolution 60/251, where it replaced its predecessor, i.e. the Commission on Human Rights. It is composed of 47 Member States elected by the General Assembly on the basis of "equitable geographic distribution" and a 3 year term on a rotational basis.

The United Natiosn Human Rigths Council derives its authority from the UN Charter, specifically Article 1(3), and serves as the principal intergovernmental forum for the promotion and protection of human rights. While it lacks enforcement powers in comparison to the Security Council, its influence lies in agenda-setting, investigative mandates, and normative development on an intergovernmental scale.

The UNHRC addresses both thematic and country-specific human rights issues through resolutions, urgent debates, interactive dialogues, and special sessions. The Universal Periodic Review (UPR) is one of its most important mechanisms, where every UN Member State approximately every four and a half years is reviewed on its human rights record.sw

The Council also oversees Special Procedures, including Special Rapporteurs and Independent Experts. It may establish Commissions of Inquiry and Fact-Finding Missions to document alleged violations. Though non-binding, its resolutions shape diplomatic engagement, development funding, and international accountability frameworks.

3. Mandate of the Committee

The UNHRC functions as a subsidiary organ of the UN General Assembly and reports annually to it. Its mandate includes promoting universal respect for human rights, preventing violations, responding to emergencies, and integrating human rights considerations throughout the UN system.

The Council cannot impose sanctions or authorize force. Instead, it exercises influence through recommendations, public reporting, fact-finding, and

diplomatic pressure. It facilitates capacity-building, technical cooperation, and institutional reform efforts.

Through mechanisms such as the UPR and Special Procedures, the Council ensures sustained monitoring and dialogue between states and international human rights institutions.

4. What is Human Rights?

Human rights are universal, inalienable entitlements inherent to every individual. They encompass civil and political rights as well as economic, social, and cultural rights. These rights are codified in international treaties and reinforced by customary international law.

In the UNHRC, Member States articulate their legal interpretations and policy approaches. Delegates must distinguish between binding treaty obligations and recommendatory instruments while balancing sovereignty and accountability.

Council outcomes include resolutions, investigative mandates, and recommendations that influence state practice and international standards.

5. Major International Human Rights Instruments

- Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)
- International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR)
- International Covenant on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights (ICESCR)
- Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW)
- Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC)

- **Convention Against Torture (CAT)**
- **International Convention on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (ICERD)**
- **Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD)**
- **The Four Geneva Conventions (1949)**
- **International Convention on the Protection of the Rights of All Migrant Workers**

6. Introduction to the Agenda

Bangladesh, home to over 170 million people, has experienced significant economic transformation over the last decade. However, economic growth has coincided with governance complexities, political polarization, demographic pressures, and environmental vulnerability.

International human rights mechanisms have documented concerns regarding civic space, digital regulatory frameworks, and the proportionality of law enforcement responses during public demonstrations. Observations submitted during the Universal Periodic Review process and communications from Special Rapporteurs have referenced issues relating to freedom of expression, due process, and institutional oversight mechanisms.

Bangladesh hosts more than one million forcibly displaced Rohingya refugees. According to United Nations humanitarian response plans, multi-year funding appeals amounting to billions of dollars have been required to sustain shelter, healthcare, food security, sanitation, and protection programming. Overcrowding, restricted livelihood access, and risks of trafficking and gender-based violence remain persistent concerns within camp settings.

Women and children face structural vulnerabilities influenced by poverty, migration, labor informality, and climate-induced displacement. Despite legislative reforms, enforcement gaps persist in areas such as child marriage prevention, labor protections, and access to justice mechanisms.

Bangladesh is among the countries most vulnerable to climate change. Cyclones, flooding, and rising sea levels contribute to internal displacement, exacerbating socioeconomic instability and increasing risks for marginalized communities.

The gravity of this agenda lies in the intersectionality of these issues: governance, development, security legislation, refugee management, and environmental resilience. The Council must deliberate cooperative frameworks that respect sovereignty while reinforcing international obligations and strengthening protection for vulnerable populations.

7. Timeline of Key Developments

- **July 2024 – Student Protests**

Nationwide student protests emerged in response to civil service quota reforms. Demonstrations spread across major urban centers, with reports of clashes between protestors and law enforcement authorities. Civil society organizations raised concerns regarding proportionality of force and protection of peaceful assembly rights.

- **August 2024 – Escalation**

Protests intensified, resulting in temporary curfews and transportation disruptions. Allegations of arrests and detentions were documented by observers. Government authorities cited public order and security concerns as justification for enforcement measures.

- **September 2024 – Internet Restrictions**

Temporary internet and communication restrictions were reportedly imposed during peak unrest periods. International observers debated the necessity and proportionality of such measures under international human rights standards.

- **January 2025 – Parliamentary Elections**

Parliamentary elections were conducted amid heightened political

polarization. Domestic and international stakeholders assessed electoral integrity, media access, and campaign conditions.

- March 2025 – Civil Society Reports

Non-governmental organizations reported increased regulatory scrutiny under digital and security frameworks. UN experts requested clarifications regarding safeguards for freedom of expression and association.

- Early 2026 – Continued Engagement

Dialogue between Bangladesh and international human rights mechanisms continued through formal submissions, UPR follow-up processes, and thematic consultations addressing institutional reforms.

8. Violations Affecting Women and Children

Women and children in Bangladesh face multifaceted vulnerabilities shaped by socio-economic inequality, displacement, and enforcement gaps. Gender-based violence, including domestic abuse, sexual harassment, and exploitation, remains a documented concern in national and international reporting.

Child marriage persists despite statutory prohibitions. Socioeconomic hardship and entrenched social norms contribute to early marriages, adversely affecting educational continuity and maternal health outcomes.

Human trafficking networks exploit vulnerable women and minors for forced labor and cross-border exploitation. Bangladesh is identified as both a source and transit country in regional trafficking patterns. While enforcement efforts exist, victim rehabilitation and conviction consistency remain areas for strengthening.

In refugee settlements, women and children experience elevated protection risks including inadequate sanitation privacy, limited formal education access, and exposure to exploitation. Humanitarian actors emphasize safe spaces, psychosocial support, and gender-responsive programming.

Climate-induced displacement further exacerbates risks of child labor, economic exploitation, and interrupted schooling. OHCHR and UNICEF reports stress the importance of integrated child protection systems, survivor-centered justice mechanisms, and strengthened community awareness initiatives.

Addressing these challenges requires coordinated institutional reform, enforcement of existing legislation, targeted social services, and sustained international cooperation.

9. QARMA – Questions A Resolution Must Answer

1. **How will vulnerable populations be systematically identified and monitored?**
2. **What accountability mechanisms address allegations of excessive force?**
3. **How can digital regulations align with freedom of expression obligations?**
4. **What safeguards protect refugees and stateless persons?**
5. **How will gender-based violence reporting mechanisms be strengthened?**
6. **What protections ensure civil society independence?**
7. **How can child marriage reduction strategies be enforced effectively?**
8. **What funding mechanisms support sustainable capacity building?**
9. **How will sovereignty concerns be balanced with international obligations?**
10. **What measurable indicators ensure transparency and compliance?**

SoFurther Reading

- **https://www.ohchr.org**
- **https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr**
- **https://www.unicef.org**
- **https://www.unhcr.org**
- **https://reliefweb.int**
- **https://www.amnesty.org**
- **https://www.hrw.org**

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